CLIENT ACQUISITION PLAYBOOK

A practical guide for developers & freelancers

Find the right prospects, start professional conversations, understand requirements, send clear proposals, and follow up without sounding pushy.

Use this guide as a repeatable process—not a promise of guaranteed clients. Your results depend on your portfolio, offer, communication, consistency, and market.

Inside this guide

• Where to find potential clients

• How to approach clients with ready-to-send messages

• How to run a discovery call and ask the right questions

• How to prepare a proposal and quotation

• How to discuss budget and close the deal

• Follow-up templates, red flags, and a 7-day action plan

Prepared for practical use • Web development, apps, AI automation & digital services

1. Start with a clear service offer

Clients rarely buy “coding” by itself. They buy an outcome: more enquiries, easier bookings, faster operations, a professional online presence, or a working product.

- **Website development:** business websites, landing pages, e-commerce stores, portfolios, booking websites.
- **App development:** MVPs, internal business apps, dashboards, customer portals.
- **AI & automation:** lead capture, spreadsheet-to-email workflows, enquiry routing, reporting, repetitive-task automation.
- **Support & maintenance:** bug fixes, speed improvements, integrations, ongoing updates.

Make the offer specific: “I help clinics get more enquiries with a fast, mobile-friendly website and a simple enquiry form” is clearer than “I do all IT services.”

2. Where to find potential clients

- **Warm network:** friends, former colleagues, college contacts, business owners you already know. Ask for introductions, not favours.
- **LinkedIn:** search founders, clinic owners, agency owners, operations managers, and businesses posting about growth or outdated systems.
- **Google Maps / Business Profiles:** look for relevant businesses with no website, broken links, outdated information, or poor mobile experience. Verify each lead manually.
- **Instagram and Facebook:** local businesses, coaches, restaurants, event teams, and service providers who rely on DMs but lack a clear enquiry process.
- **Freelance platforms and agency partnerships:** apply to projects that match your skills; offer white-label development to marketing agencies when appropriate.
- **Referrals:** after a successful delivery, ask the client whether they know one business with a similar need.

Lead tracker columns: Business name | Contact person | Website/social link | Observed issue | Service fit | First message date | Follow-up date | Status | Next step.

3. Before you message a prospect

- Check what the business actually does and who appears to make decisions.
- Find one real, specific improvement opportunity. Do not claim a website is missing or broken unless you checked.
- Prepare one relevant portfolio example, demo, or short explanation of your process.
- Keep the first message short and personalised. Avoid sending the same long pitch to everyone.

4. Ready-to-send outreach messages

Template A — business website:

Hi [Name], I came across [Business Name] and noticed [specific observation]. I help businesses improve their online presence through fast, mobile-friendly websites. A simple [relevant feature] could make it easier for customers to [desired outcome]. Would you be open to a brief 10–15 minute conversation this week?

Template B — app or custom software:

Hi [Name], I saw that your team is working on [specific business/process]. I work on web/app development and can help build a solution around your workflow. If this is a current priority, I'd be happy to understand the requirements and suggest a practical approach. Would a short discovery call be useful?

Template C — AI automation:

Hi [Name], quick idea for [Business Name]: if your team spends time manually handling [enquiries/reports/follow-ups], part of that workflow may be automatable. I build practical automation workflows and can first map the process before recommending anything. Would you be open to discussing how it works today?

Template D — agency partnership:

Hi [Name], I'm reaching out to explore a development partnership. Our team supports web development, app development, and automation work, including project-based delivery. If you ever need additional delivery capacity, I'd be glad to share relevant work and discuss your process.

Template E — warm introduction:

Hi [Name], I'm currently taking on projects in [specific service]. If you know a business that needs [specific outcome], would you be comfortable introducing us? No pressure—happy to share a short portfolio first.

5. What to say when they reply

Do not jump straight into a price. First, understand the problem and whether you can deliver what they need.

- "Thanks for replying. What outcome are you hoping this project will achieve?"
- "What are you doing today, and what is not working well?"
- "Which features are essential for the first version?"
- "Do you have a target launch date?"
- "Who will provide content, images, access, and approvals?"
- "Do you have a budget range allocated? That will help me suggest a realistic scope."

6. Discovery call checklist

- **Business goal:** What problem should the website/app/automation solve?
- **Users:** Who will use it—customers, staff, admins, or multiple roles?
- **Scope:** Pages, features, integrations, roles, reports, notifications, and admin tools.
- **Current setup:** Existing website, domain, hosting, code, database, APIs, and third-party tools.
- **Content & ownership:** Who supplies copy, images, branding, and data? Who owns accounts and source code?
- **Timeline:** Milestones, review windows, launch date, and dependencies.
- **Budget & decision:** Budget range, decision-maker, approval process, and payment method.
- **Success criteria:** What does "done" mean, and how will acceptance be confirmed?

End the call by summarising the requirements and agreeing on the next step: a written scope, a proposal, or a second technical discussion.

7. How to quote and send a proposal

Avoid giving a final fixed price before the scope is clear. Separate must-have features from optional add-ons.

- Project summary and business objective
- Included pages/features and explicit exclusions
- Technology/integrations, where relevant
- Deliverables and milestone dates
- Client responsibilities and assumptions
- Total fee, taxes if applicable, payment milestones, and proposal validity
- Revision limits, change-request process, support period, and maintenance terms
- Ownership, handover, credentials, and acceptance criteria

Useful wording: “Based on the scope discussed, the estimated fee is [amount]. This includes [deliverables]. Anything outside the agreed scope will be estimated and approved separately before work begins.”

8. Budget conversation and negotiation

- Ask for the client's budget range before designing a solution that may not fit it.
- If the budget is low, reduce scope or phase the project. Do not silently promise the full scope for less.
- Explain value through deliverables, reliability, maintainability, and business outcomes—not only hours of coding.
- If the client says the price is high: “I understand. We can review the must-have features and create a smaller first phase that fits your budget.”
- Do not guarantee sales, leads, rankings, or business results that you cannot control.

9. Closing the deal professionally

A deal is not fully secured by a verbal yes. Confirm the scope, price, dates, responsibilities, and payment terms in writing.

- Send the final proposal/quotation and invite questions.
- Get written approval of the scope and terms.
- Use a signed agreement or written acceptance appropriate to the project.
- Collect the agreed advance or first milestone payment before starting substantial work.
- Start only after access, content, and key dependencies are ready.
- Send a kickoff note with milestones, communication channel, and next update date.

Closing message: “Thanks for confirming. I’ll send the final scope and milestone plan for written approval. Once the agreed initial payment and required materials are in place, we can begin with [first milestone].”

10. Follow-up templates

After the first outreach (3–5 business days later):

> **Hi [Name], just following up on my note about [specific opportunity]. If this is a priority, I can share a concise outline of the possible approach. If the timing isn't right, no worries.**

After sending a proposal:

> **Hi [Name], checking whether you had a chance to review the proposal for [project]. I'm happy to clarify the scope or adjust priorities if needed. Would [day] be a convenient time to discuss?**

Close the loop:

> **Hi [Name], I'll close the loop for now so I don't crowd your inbox. If [project/need] becomes a priority later, feel free to reach out. Thanks for your time.**

11. Red flags to watch for

- They demand substantial unpaid work or a complete custom demo before agreeing on terms.
- The scope keeps expanding while the price and timeline are expected to stay unchanged.
- They refuse written scope, milestone clarity, or any reasonable payment structure.
- They request suspicious payments, ask you to forward money, or share questionable links/files.
- They promise future exposure or referrals instead of paying for the agreed work.
- They ask for guarantees beyond your control. Clarify what you can and cannot promise.

12. A practical 7-day client acquisition plan

- **Day 1:** Choose one service and one target customer type. Prepare a concise offer.
- **Day 2:** Create or polish one relevant portfolio example or demo.
- **Day 3:** Research 15–20 suitable businesses and note a specific opportunity for each.
- **Day 4:** Send 5–10 personalised messages; track them and avoid spam.
- **Day 5:** Publish one useful case study, tip, or demo showing how you solve a business problem.
- **Day 6:** Follow up politely with earlier prospects and contact potential agency partners.
- **Day 7:** Review replies, calls, objections, and conversions. Improve the message and repeat.

Consistency matters more than one large batch of generic messages. Respect platform rules, privacy, and each prospect's request not to be contacted.

13. A simple daily routine

- 20 minutes: research and qualify leads
- 30 minutes: send a small batch of personalised outreach messages
- 15 minutes: follow up on previous conversations
- 20 minutes: improve portfolio, demo, or case study
- 10 minutes: update the lead tracker and next actions

Final reminder

Your developer experience helps you estimate, communicate, and deliver. Client acquisition is a separate skill: understand a business problem, show relevant proof, communicate clearly, and follow a consistent process. Start small, record what works, and improve each week.